The Rebuild — Mindset Workbook

This is a practical working guide to why routine breaks down, and how you can rebuild it so it actually holds this time.

This isn't some motivational pep talk. It's a set of tools covering everything from a self-audit, a values check, a contingency plan, a habit-design framework, a setback protocol, and a weekly check-in, that work whether or not you feel like doing them, because that's the whole point.

Part 1: The self-audit

Before you build something that lasts, we need to understand why the last attempt didn't. Not just being vague saying "I lost motivation", we need to be specific and honest with ourselves... nobody else is reading this but you.
Reflect and write your answers:

1. What was going on in your life the last time your routine fell apart? (how was work, relationships, injury, moving house, etc.)
2. What was the very first thing that slipped? Was it training, food, sleep, or something else?
3. How long after that first slip did the whole routine collapse? Days? Weeks?
4. What did you tell yourself at the time to justify skipping/stopping? ("I'll start Monday", "I've ruined it now anyway")
5. Looking back, what's the earliest point you could have caught it, if you'd had a plan?

This last question is the entire point of the rest of this workbook. Relying on motivation isn't the plan, having a physical plan of action is the plan.

Part 2: Why you actually want this

"I want to lose weight" and "I want to feel like myself again" are not the same goal, and they don't survive setbacks the same way.
Outcome based goals (wanting a number on the scale) are fragile and don't paint the whole picture... they can be hit or missed and give you no instructions for the next day if/when the goal is achieved. Identity based goals ("I'm someone who trains, regardless of how the day or week's gone") survive a bad week, because the goal was never about that one week, it was about showing up regardless of emotion and not derailing.
Reflect and write your answers:

- What's the outcome you think you want? (be honest, is it a number on the scale? A look? An event? whatever it is)
- Underneath that outcome, what do you actually want to feel or be able to do? (Is this more energy? Improved confidence?, Being more capable?, whatever's true for you)
- Finish this sentence: "I'm someone who ___." Write it as already true, then work backwards to what that person actually does weekly.

Keep that identity sentence somewhere you'll see it, like setting it as your phone background. It's not affirmation nonsense, it's a decision-making shortcut for the moments when you're tired and deciding whether to train.

Part 3: The contingency planner

Relying on willpower fails the moment life gets hard, it's not a personal weakness, it's just how decision-making under fatigue and stress works for everyone.
A pre-decided "if this, then that" plan removes the decision from the moment you're least equipped to make it well, reducing 'decision fatigue'. This is the same principle behind implementation intentions used in behaviour change research: deciding in advance, in calm conditions, removes the need to negotiate with the 'weaker version' of yourself in the moment.
Fill in your own plan — be specific, vague plans don't get followed:

- IF I miss a planned session... THEN I will...
- IF I'm away from home / travelling for work... THEN I will...
- IF I get injured or something hurts... THEN I will...
- IF a stressful life event happens (deadline, family issue, etc.)... THEN I will...
- IF I have a genuinely bad week and eat/train nothing like planned... THEN I will (hint: the answer is never "write off the week and restart Monday")...

Part 4: Building the habit so it doesn't need willpower

The goal is to make the behaviour require as little decision-making as possible. Two tools that consistently work in behaviour change research: habit stacking (attaching a new habit to an existing, already-automatic one) and reducing friction (making the good choice the easy one).

Habit stacking

Format: "After I [existing habit], I will [new habit]." Example: "After I make my morning coffee, I will lay out my gym kit for that evening." This can also be applied to completing boring, mundane tasks. Example "While I complete my steps for the day, I will plan out my meals for the rest of the week and write a shopping list"
Write your own stacks (aim for 2-3).

Reducing friction — make the good choice the easy one

- Prep gym kit the night before, not the morning of
- Batch-cook 2-3 days of food at once rather than deciding fresh every meal
- Book sessions in your calendar like any other appointment - not "if I have time"

Write down two pieces of friction you can remove this week.

Part 5: The setback protocol

A missed session or a bad day is data, not a verdict. The damage almost never comes from the miss itself, it comes from the spiral that happens downstream of that event, where one skipped session turns into a skipped week because of an all-or-nothing story you told yourself.
Here's the specific sequence to follow within 24-48 hours of a slip, before the story takes hold.

1

Name it without the story

Write down what actually happened, in neutral terms. "I missed Tuesday's session", not "I've ruined the whole week again." The second version is a prediction, not a fact.

2

Ask what actually caused it

Go back to Part 1's questions. Was it a genuine one-off (illness, emergency) or a pattern repeating? Different causes will need different responses.

3

Decide the very next action, not the whole week

You don't need to fix the week. You need to decide what you're doing at the next scheduled session or meal. That's the only decision that matters right now.

4

Remove one piece of friction before the next attempt

If the same thing derailed you twice, that's a friction problem, not a discipline problem, go back to Part 4 and change something concrete.

If you've followed this sequence and you're still stuck in the same pattern after a few cycles, that's exactly the kind of blind spot ongoing coaching exists to catch, you can't always see your own pattern from inside it.

Part 6: Weekly check-in template

Reuse this template weekly. It'll take five minutes, on the same day each week. The point isn't to grade or judge yourself, it's to catch things slipping early, while it's still a one-week problem and not a two-month problem.
Check-in item:

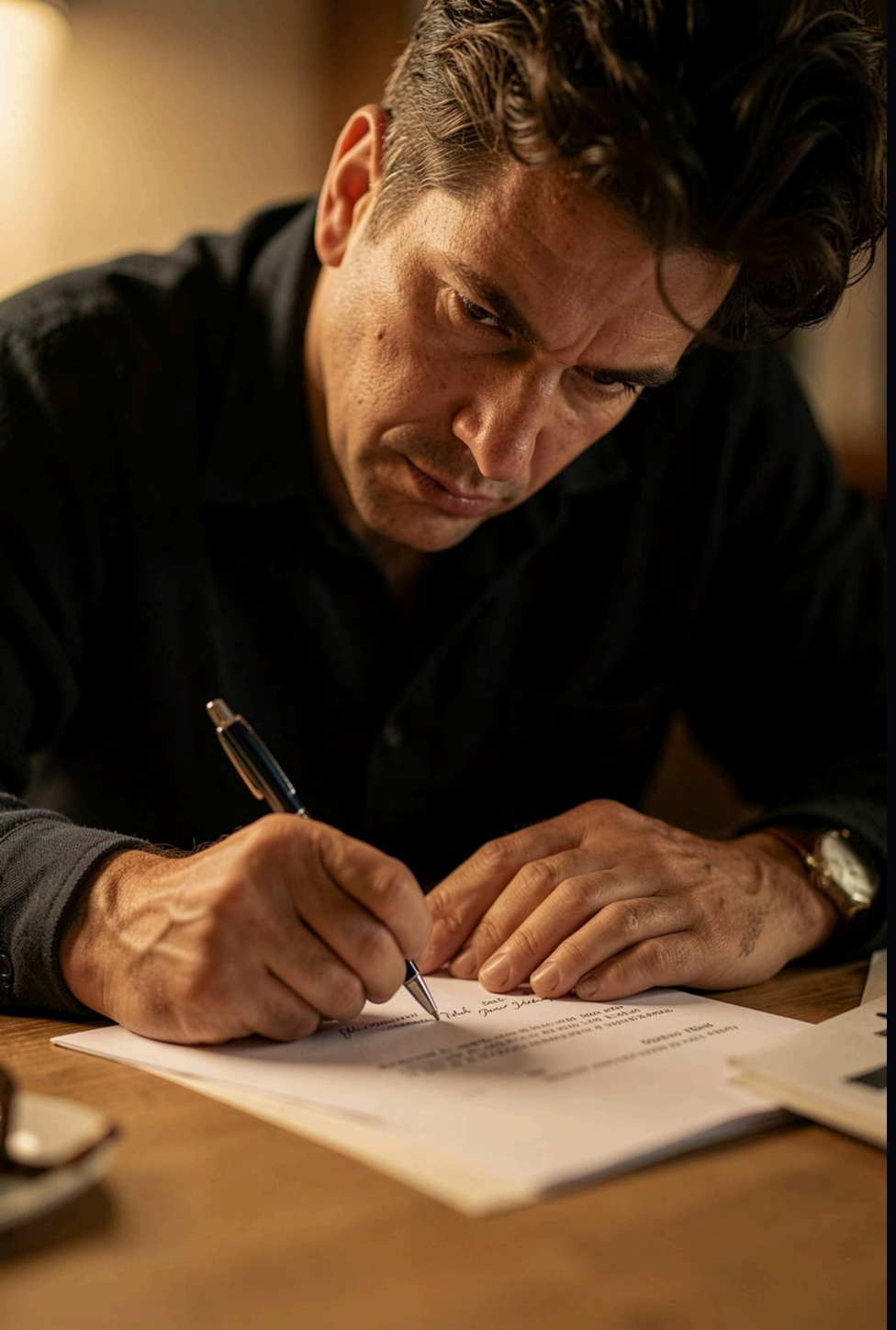
#	Check-in item
1) Number of sessions planned and completed?	
2) Nutrition — on track most days? (Y/N)	
3) Sleep — average hours?	
4) Stress level (1-10)?	
5) Energy in training (1-10)?	

What went well this week?

What slipped, and why (be specific)?

One change you can make for next week?

Do this for 4-6 weeks and you'll have a written record of your actual patterns, not just your memory of them, which tends to round bad weeks up and good weeks down.



Part 7: Your Rebuild commitment

Not a contract, not a legal document — just a clear statement of what you're actually agreeing to, written by you, so it's harder to quietly renegotiate with yourself in three weeks.

Write your answers:

I'm doing this because...

_____

The minimum I'm committing to on a genuinely bad week is...

_____

If I notice myself repeating the pattern from Part 1, the first person/thing I'll turn to for accountability is...

_____

Signed: _____ Date: _____

A note on what this workbook can't do

This gives you the tools to see your own patterns and pre-plan for the obvious disruptions. What it can't do is spot the pattern you genuinely can't see yourself, or adjust your plan in real time when something you didn't anticipate happens - **that's the actual value of ongoing coaching.**

If you've worked through this honestly and you're still stuck, that's not a personal failure. It's just the limit of a self-guided tool.